

SDEV2004 – Software for the Global Market
Continuous Assessment – Phase 1
Individual Cultural and Usability Analysis

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Group Name (from Brightspace): Group 8 – Cross Paths

1. Website Selected for Analysis

Which existing website(s) in the chosen target area did you review?

Website URL: <https://bumble.com/en/bff>

Describe the website's purpose and the type of users it is designed for.

- Bumble BFF is a culturally adaptive speed-friending and social discovery web platform, an extension of Bumble's dating app. Its purpose is for users to connect and create friendships, using a personalised profile with photos, short bio, and interest tags. The matches with potential friends are through swipe-based interface borrowed from the dating mode.
- The target audience users are adults aged 18-35 seeking new friendships in modern environments. It is available on iOS, Android, and website, operating globally, including the three target cultural places: Ireland, Brazil, and Ukraine. As a Brazilian, I have personal reference point for evaluating both platforms, Bumble and Cross Paths.

2. Cultural Analysis

Your findings from applying the cultural dimensions chosen by the group.

Cultural Dimensions Considered

Dimension	Explanation
Individualism vs Collectivism (IDV) Hofstede	This dimension measures whether a culture prioritises individual goals and autonomy (individualism) or group belonging, shared identity, and collective decision-making (collectivism). Ireland scores 70 (high individualism), Brazil 38 (moderate collectivism), Ukraine 25 (strongly collectivist). Bumble BFF's design is firmly individualist: it is built around the solo user's profile and personal swiping decisions, with no mechanism for group discovery, shared connections, or community belonging.
Uncertainty Avoidance (UA) Hofstede	This dimension measures a culture's tolerance for ambiguity and unstructured situations. High-UA cultures expect detailed information, verified sources, and structured processes before committing to social situations. Ireland scores 35 (low UA), Brazil 76 (high), Ukraine 95 (very high). Bumble BFF's minimal information architecture, absence of host

	verification, and informal tone reflect low-UA assumptions that do not serve high-UA user groups well.
High-Context vs Low-Context Communication (Hall)	Low-context cultures (e.g. Ireland, most Northern European countries) communicate meaning directly and explicitly. High-context cultures (e.g. Brazil, Ukraine) rely more heavily on warmth, relationship cues, shared understanding, and non-verbal signals. Bumble BFF's copy is direct and minimal, a low-context approach that works for Irish users but may feel impersonal or emotionally insufficient for Brazilian users and too informal for Ukrainian users.

Cultural Observations

Explain how the website reflects cultural assumptions. You may consider aspects such as: layout and information density, navigation structure, colour and imagery, language and tone, symbols and icons.

For each observation:

- Describe what you observed
- Explain why it may work well or poorly for different cultural dimensions
- Identify anything that is particularly effective, problematic, or interesting

Explain **why these issues matter for usability or cultural adaptation**.

- **Layout and Information Density:** Bumble BFF uses a card-based swipe layout that displays one profile at a time, with a photo, name, age, and a short bio of approximately 300 characters. The design is visually clean and minimalist. For Irish users (low UA, high individualism), this feels natural and efficient. For Brazilian users, the visual-first approach is broadly comfortable, though the complete absence of social context, who else is on this platform, what events are happening, is a gap. The low information density is most problematic for Ukrainian users, who require structured, detailed information before any social commitment. However, my primary focus here is the Brazilian perspective: the card layout does not tell me anything about a potential friend's social context, mutual connections, or group affiliations. This is a real shortcoming for a moderately collectivist culture where shared social circles are a key trust signal.
- **Navigation Structure:** Bumble BFF's navigation is minimal, a bottom tab bar with Home, Profile, Messages, and Match. There is no onboarding guidance once inside the app, no contextual help, and no community or group discovery section. The entire experience is self-directed. For high-IDV, low-UA users (Ireland), this works. For Brazilian users who are moderate collectivists and oriented toward group social behaviour, the absence of any community navigation, no way to find local groups, shared events, or social communities, is a meaningful design gap. The platform assumes you already know who you want to find, rather than helping you find your social tribe.
- **Colour and Imagery:** Bumble BFF uses a warm yellow palette with white backgrounds and lifestyle photography showing happy, diverse groups of young people. From a Brazilian cultural

perspective, the warmth and energy of the colour palette is broadly well-suited. Yellow is an energetic, socially positive colour that resonates with Brazilian expectations of expressiveness and vitality. The lifestyle photography is similarly aligned with how Brazilian social culture presents itself – joyful, group-oriented, and informal. However, the imagery consistently shows pairs or small groups in social settings rather than communities. This subtly reinforces an individualist design logic that does not fully reflect the collective social experience that Brazilian users typically expect from a social platform.

- **Language and Tone:** The copy throughout Bumble BFF is casual, emoji-rich, and enthusiastic: "Make new friends, Find your people", "No swiping required, just good vibes." From a Brazilian perspective, this warm, expressive tone is culturally aligned. Brazilian communication norms (high-context, expressive, emotionally direct) are broadly served by this register. However, the platform is entirely in English and offers no Brazilian Portuguese localisation in the default web experience. This is a significant usability failure: Brazilian newcomers to Dublin who are not yet confident in English see a platform that does not acknowledge their language at all. Language is not cosmetic; it is a fundamental trust and inclusion signal. Seeing your native language signals that the platform was made for you.
- **Symbols and Icons:** Bumble BFF uses heart icons, bee logos, and standard social icons (chat bubbles, profile, settings). There are no group icons, community symbols, mutual connection indicators, or social energy cues. For a Brazilian user, the absence of symbols that convey social momentum, how many people are on here? who else is looking for friends in Dublin right now? It is a missed opportunity. Social proof icons, group activity indicators, and mutual connection signals would directly address the collectivist trust-building pattern that Brazilian users rely on. The current icon vocabulary is entirely individual-to-individual and contains nothing that signals a community.

3. Cultural Implications

Your application must support **two countries and languages other than English**.

Explain how the website's design might work **better or worse for these countries**.

Your analysis should clearly link your observations to the cultural dimensions selected by your group.

Country	Language	Cultural Dimension(s)	Website Critique
Brazil	Portuguese (Brazilian) pt_BR	Uncertainty Avoidance (76, high but lower than Ukraine); Individualism vs. Collectivism (38, moderately collectivist); High-Context Communication (Hall)	Bumble BFF performs partially well for Brazilian users on a surface level – the warm colour palette, emoji-heavy copy, and casual social tone broadly align with Brazilian cultural expectations. However, the platform's core architecture is individualist and fails the collectivist dimension in several ways. There is no way for a Brazilian user to see group social events, find communities of people with shared interests, or see who else is attending a gathering before committing. Brazilian trust is built through shared social circles and mutual connections, not through one-on-one anonymous swiping. The lack of Brazilian Portuguese localisation is a fundamental usability barrier. And

			while the tone is warm, the visual social vocabulary contains no social proof signals – no attendee counts, no mutual connections, no group activity indicators – that Brazilian users rely on to feel safe and motivated to engage.
Ukraine	Ukrainian uk-UA	Uncertainty Avoidance (95, very high); Individualism vs. Collectivism (25, strongly collectivist); High-Context Communication (Hall)	Bumble BFF works poorly for Ukrainian users. The swipe-based single-card format provides no structured information about events, no host verification, no attendee lists, and no agenda. The informal, emoji-heavy copy reads as untrustworthy and juvenile to a high-UA user who equates formality with credibility. There is no step-by-step navigation, no breadcrumb guidance, and no institutional trust cues. The collectivist dimension is also poorly served: there are no group discovery features or community spaces. Ukrainian users want to know who the host is, what the agenda is, how many people are attending, and whether the organiser is verified – none of which Bumble BFF provides. The one partial exception is brand recognition – Ukrainian users may feel slightly more comfortable on a globally known platform than an unknown local one. But that baseline trust doesn't compensate for the absence of verified information, host credentials, or structured event details.

You may consider aspects such as: layout and information density, navigation structure, colour and imagery, language and tone, symbols and icons.

For each observation:

- Describe what you observed
- Explain why it may work well or poorly for the different countries.
- Identify anything that is particularly effective, problematic, or interesting

Brazil – Individualism vs. Collectivism and Language:

- What was observed: Bumble BFF's card-based format connects users one-to-one with no group or community dimension. The platform is entirely in English with no Portuguese localisation available in the default web experience.
- Why it matters for Brazil: Brazilian social culture is moderately collectivist (IDV = 38). Trust and social motivation are built through shared groups, mutual connections, and visible social

activity. A platform that only enables anonymous one-on-one matching lacks the social context that Brazilian users need to feel comfortable engaging. The absence of Portuguese also means the platform is not genuinely accessible to Brazilian newcomers who are still learning English, which is particularly relevant in the CrossPaths context of newcomers arriving in Dublin.

- What is effective: The warm tone and emoji usage translate well culturally. What is problematic: the individualist architecture and English-only experience are significant gaps for Brazilian users.

- **Ukraine – Uncertainty Avoidance and Information Structure:**

- What was observed: Bumble BFF's event or meeting structure is minimal to non-existent. There are no host credentials, no agendas, no safety badges, and no verified profiles.
- Why it matters for Ukraine: With a UA score of 95, Ukrainian users need explicit, detailed information and institutional trust signals before committing to any social situation. The current design creates a high-anxiety experience for these users: the lack of structure is not just unhelpful, but it is destroying trust.
- What is problematic: The design assumes a universal comfort with ambiguity that most Ukrainian users do not share. This is not merely a translation problem, but it is a fundamental mismatch.
- Both observations reinforce a core conclusion: cultural adaptation in social platforms cannot be limited to translation. It requires rethinking layout, information architecture, and trust vocabulary for each cultural context.

Important:

This section must reflect **your own individual analysis of the website**. You may refer to the cultural dimensions selected by your group, but the observations, explanations, and critique should be **your own work and should not simply repeat material from the group Phase 1 report**.

4. Influence on Group Design/work

Explain **how your analysis informed your group's design decisions**.

Your explanation should make clear **what you contributed personally** and how your analysis shaped the group's thinking. You should identify **at least one PoV, hypothesis, or design guideline** that was influenced by your analysis. You may refer to areas such as: user descriptions or user needs, point of view (PoV) statements, hypotheses, cultural adaptation decisions, design and development guidelines.

You should clearly describe:

- The **key insights or issues** you identified during your analysis
- Bumble BFF has a warm visual tone that superficially suits Brazilian users, but its individualist architecture fundamentally fails the moderately collectivist Brazilian user. The platform has no group features, no social proof indicators, and no way to build trust through shared social context before meeting.
- The complete absence of Brazilian Portuguese localisation is a functional exclusion. Not offering a user's native language signals the product was not designed for them. This directly

supported the group's decision to treat Portuguese localisation as a core requirement, not an optional enhancement.

- Bumble BFF treats all users as individualist decision-makers, comfortable swiping and deciding alone. This is a critical gap for both Brazilian and Ukrainian users: Brazilians need social proof and collective energy; Ukrainians need structural certainty and verified authority.
- The total absence of community or group discovery was one of the clearest gaps I identified. For a moderately collectivist culture, this is a structural problem, not a minor one. This directly supported the group's decision to build a Communities section into CrossPaths, where users can find interest-based groups before committing to any one-on-one interaction.
- How these insights were **shared with the group**
- I shared these observations during our Phase 1 collaborative sessions and persona development work. I argued that the pt_BR locale needed different interface elements entirely, attendee grids, group activity indicators, social proof signals, and language adaptation, not just a colour and tone change. Bumble BFF's single global design cannot serve Ukrainian and Brazilian users simultaneously because the trust signals they need are fundamentally different. This influenced the decision to implement genuinely different card layouts per locale rather than a single adaptive card.
- How they **influenced specific design decisions** in the group Phase 1 work
- PoV Statement for Brazil (PoV 2): My analysis of how Bumble BFF fails Brazilian users directly informed PoV 2: Rafael (pt_BR) needs to feel socially energised and personally connected before and during events. The observation that the platform has no social proof signals, no attendee previews, and no group features was the evidence base for the insight that "impersonal, rigid, or visually flat interfaces suppress the social motivation Rafael needs to engage."
- Hypothesis H3: H3 came directly from my observation that Bumble BFF has no visual attendee feed and no way to gauge a social event's energy before committing: "We believe that implementing a visual-first event discovery feed that foregrounds attendee photos, personality tags, and social connection indicators for pt_BR users will result in higher event engagement and faster attendance decisions."
- Brazilian Locale Design Elements: I recommended UI elements entirely absent from Bumble BFF, warm orange and yellow palette, emoji-inclusive copy in Portuguese, attendee count indicators, group activity thumbnails, and personality tags. The attendee count is now visible on every CrossPaths event card, and the Communities page implements the group discovery layer I argued for.
- Portuguese Localisation as Core Requirement: I argued that Portuguese localisation was a fundamental trust requirement, not cosmetic work. In the CrossPaths build, the pt_BR locale sits in the main navigation bar alongside English and Ukrainian – visible immediately, not buried in settings. That placement reflects exactly the argument I made.
- Event Detail Pages and the Ukrainian Trust Gap: One issue I flagged that remains only partially addressed is the absence of host verification on event pages. The current build shows a date, location, and description, but no organiser credentials, safety badge, or structured agenda – all of which Ukrainian users need before committing. This remains an open design problem my analysis specifically anticipated.

- Overall, my Bumble BFF analysis gave the group a concrete negative reference point for the Brazilian locale: a platform that gets the visual tone partially right but fails entirely on the social architecture, language, and group features.